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Participant Information and Consent Form — Template

LS100 — Module 00A · Research Plans & Proposals

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This is a teaching template, not an approved consent form

This document exists so you have somewhere to start, and so you can see what informed consent actually has to cover. **It has not been reviewed or approved by any ethics committee, and it does not by itself make your study permissible.**

Every `[BRACKETED ITEM]` is a placeholder you must replace with your own study's details. Do not hand this to anyone with brackets still in it.

Before you record any person, follow the pathway in **"Before you use this template"** below. Harvard publishes its own authoritative consent templates — **HRP-502 (Adult Consent)** and **HRP-502-c (Exempt Research Consent Script)** — in the ESTR Library under *Templates and Forms*; use the **HUA**-labelled versions. If anything here conflicts with what the Committee on the Use of Human Subjects (CUHS) tells you, **CUHS is right and this document is wrong**.

1. Before you use this template

1.a. What this template does not cover

Anyone under 18. This template is written for adults who can consent for themselves. Recording a child requires permission from a parent or guardian *and* age-appropriate assent from the child, on different forms. It is also a regulatory dead end: the exemption that otherwise covers identifiable recording of public behaviour, 45 CFR 46.104(d)(2)(iii), explicitly **may not be applied to research involving children**. If your project involves minors, talk to the instructor and CUHS before you plan anything else.

Anyone who is not comfortable in English. Consent must be given in a language the participant genuinely understands, and translated consent documents carry their own requirements. Do not translate this yourself or work through a friend of the participant. Contact the instructor and CUHS first.

Anyone who cannot consent for themselves, for any reason. Same instruction: ask first.

If your project needs any of these, that is not a reason to abandon the question — it is a reason to start the conversation early, because the approvals take longer.

1.b. The pathway you actually have to follow

Harvard's position on course projects is narrower than students usually assume, so read this carefully.

A class project run **purely to teach research methods** does not require the course instructor to file an IRB application. Harvard states that directly on Undergraduate Research and Course Projects: *"It is no longer necessary for the Course Instructor to submit an IRB application when the purpose of the class is for educational purposes only."*

That is not the same as "nothing is required." On the same page, Harvard is explicit that **all undergraduate research starts with the Undergraduate Research Training Program (URTP)**, and that *"whether or not your undergraduate research project requires IRB review, ethics training is a required part of the URTP."*

So your sequence is:

1. **Start at the URTP Portal.** Identify a Research Supervisor and complete the required ethics training (IRB-led or CITI).
2. **Complete the URTP Decision Form.** It is reviewed by an IRB regulatory expert — this is how it gets decided whether your specific project needs IRB review, and it is not a formality you self-assess.
3. **Do not self-certify as "exempt."** CUHS is unambiguous in its FAQs: *"The regulatory category of 'exempt' research must be reviewed by CUHS prior to being carried out. Whether your study is exempt is a determination made by the designated CUHS staff person who reviews your application."*
4. **If review is needed**, submissions go through **ESTR** at irb.harvard.edu and require an HUID. An undergraduate may be listed as PI, but only with a PI-eligible faculty sponsor also listed.
5. **Only then start recording.** If the initial intent is for the data to be used beyond the classroom, Harvard puts the responsibility on the faculty advisor to resolve this **before the project begins**.

Where this template runs out

Three things you must ask CUHS about rather than infer from this document:

- **Recording-specific requirements.** Harvard's detailed guidance pages are login-gated, and the requirements may change periodically. Please check guidance pages to see what exactly you require for the type of data you will be collecting.
- **State recording law.** Massachusetts requires all-party consent to record.

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> - **How your data must be stored.** Identifiable video and audio plausibly sit at Harvard risk classification **Level 3**, and can reach **Level 4** where material is treated as biometric or where disclosure could put someone at risk. Do not guess the level, and do not assume a personal computer is an acceptable storage; check the CUHS website.
>
> CUHS: cuhs.harvard.edu · cuhs@harvard.edu · 617-496-2847

1.c. How to fill it in

Replace every placeholder. Keep the language plain — the federal requirement at 45 CFR 46.116 is that consent begins with *"a concise and focused presentation of the key information"* in language the participant can understand, and contains **no exculpatory language** (nothing asking them to waive rights). Short sentences beat formal ones.

Print **two copies**: the participant keeps one, you keep one. Give them time to read it and ask questions before anyone signs.

The next two pages are the participant's. This page is for you — do not hand it over.

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2. Part 1 · Participant Information Sheet

Study: [PLAIN-LANGUAGE TITLE]

Researcher: [YOUR NAME], Email: [YOUR EMAIL]

Supervisor: [INSTRUCTOR NAME], Email: [INSTRUCTOR EMAIL] LS100, Harvard University (FAS)

The short version. You are invited to take part in a student research project. Taking part means **[YOU WILL BE VIDEO / AUDIO / VIDEO AND AUDIO RECORDED]** while you [DO THE ACTIVITY], and takes about **[N] minutes** at [LOCATION]. It is **entirely voluntary**: you can say no, and you can stop at any point, without a reason and without consequence. The main thing to weigh is that **a recording of you is identifiable** — your face [AND/OR] voice can be recognised. What happens to it is below, and you control part of that overleaf.

Why this is being done, and why you. [ONE OR TWO PLAIN SENTENCES ON WHAT YOU WANT TO FIND OUT AND WHY IT MATTERS. NO JARGON.] This is a course project run for teaching purposes. [IF RESULTS MIGHT BE USED BEYOND THE CLASSROOM, SAY SO PLAINLY.] You are being asked because [REASON]; about [N] people will take part.

What you will be asked to do. [STEP ONE]; [STEP TWO]; [STEP THREE], recorded using [EQUIPMENT]. You need not do anything you are uncomfortable with, and can ask for the recording to be paused or stopped at any time.

What happens to the recording. Software extracts [WHAT YOU MEASURE], so what gets analysed is a table of numbers rather than the recording itself. Only [YOUR NAME] and the supervising instructor can see the original, unless you agree otherwise overleaf. It is kept on [SPECIFIC APPROVED STORAGE — not "my laptop"] with access restricted by [HOW], and deleted at the end of the semester **plus [30 / 60] days** after final grades — by [DATE] at the latest. The extracted numbers [WILL / WILL NOT] be kept after that. Your name never appears in any report: recordings carry a code, and the code-to-name list is stored separately and destroyed on the same schedule.

Risks, benefits, one honest limit. No physical risk beyond what you would normally experience while [ACTIVITY]. [ADD ANY STUDY-SPECIFIC RISK, OR: "We are not asking you anything personal."] The real risk is loss of privacy: if a clip of you is shown — only if you agree overleaf — **people who know you may recognise you.** Masking the eyes is not reliable anonymisation. There is no direct benefit to you. [STATE COMPENSATION, OR: "You will not be paid."]

Changing your mind, and who to contact. To withdraw, contact the researcher above at any time; your recording and everything derived from it will be deleted. After **[DATE OR MILESTONE]** data cannot be removed from a completed analysis, though the recording can still be destroyed. For questions about **your rights as a**

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participant: Committee on the Use of Human Subjects, Harvard — cuhs@harvard.edu, 617-496-2847.

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3. Part 2 · Consent and Signature

Study: `[PLAIN-LANGUAGE TITLE]`

Researcher: `[YOUR NAME]`

Instructor: `[INSTRUCTOR NAME]`

Required to take part — please write your initials beside each statement.

Initials	Statement
_____	I have read the Information Sheet, or had it read to me, and my questions have been answered.
_____	I understand taking part is voluntary and I can stop at any time, without a reason and without consequence.
_____	I understand I will be **`[VIDEO / AUDIO / VIDEO AND AUDIO]` recorded**, and that a recording of me is identifiable.
_____	I agree the student researcher and supervising instructor may view my recording and take measurements from it for this course project.
_____	I understand when my recording will be deleted, and that measurements from it `[MAY / WILL NOT]` be kept afterwards.

Optional — you can take part without agreeing to any of these. A blank box means no, and nothing changes about your participation.

Initials	Statement
_____	Short clips of my recording may be shown **in class**, to other students and the instructor.
_____	Short clips may be included in the **written project report** for this course.
_____	Short clips may be used **publicly** — a public website, public talk, or published article. I understand that once something is public it cannot reliably be withdrawn.

Signatures. The researcher signs to confirm they explained the study, gave the Information Sheet, answered questions, and that consent was given freely.

	Name (printed)	Signature	Date
Participant	_____	_____	_____
Student researcher	_____	_____	_____

Sign two copies. The participant keeps one; the researcher keeps the other, stored separately from the recordings.

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